

Financing Digital Innovation Ecosystems in the Majority World: Challenges and Opportunities

Venue:

Conference room 9 at the UN Headquarters, New York

Date and Time:

15 December 2025 | 11.45 AM – 01.00 PM EST

Organizers:

Global Digital Justice Forum, represented by members IT for Change and Association for Progressive Communications (APC)

UNDP

Co-Develop

Session Description:

Even as the connectivity divide persists in many parts of the world, the AI economy presents [new challenges](#) – gaps in compute infrastructure, quality datasets, and digital skills – that bring the risk that the Majority World will be permanently left behind.

From bridging connectivity and compute infrastructure divides to creating locally meaningful data and AI ecosystems, an urgent infusion of resources is needed to democratize the new innovation economy, making it possible for all countries and societies to pursue their vision of development and well-being.

However, the World Summit on Information Society (WSIS) +20 moment is sobering. Projected Official Development Assistance (ODA) cuts will impact the poorest countries and vital services the hardest. Southern governments face public financing deficits that impact digital infrastructural capabilities and other essential services. The gap between ODA and what is needed for the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and the implementation of the WSIS vision is widening. And additional resources and financing mechanisms are needed to bridge this gap, as ODA alone cannot meet all development challenges.

Relying on private sector financing to bridge the gap has historically presented challenges, with the market not being able to deliver internet access, digital infrastructure, and capacity equitably, with democratization of benefits. Venture capital funding prioritizes market sectors that promise quick return on investment, often [benefiting](#) dominant actors and incumbent monopolies rather than local companies. The work of scholars like [Mazzucato](#) demonstrates how the “billions to trillions” narrative of blended finance closing financing gaps in development by leveraging private investment at scale has not really panned out. Blended finance, therefore, needs to be strategically re-framed in order to enable effective de-risking through structural transformation that delivers on public value creation.

The key question then is how an effective and sustainable financing architecture can be imagined for digital innovation that provides the normative basis for equitable development and the realization of human rights for all in the digital age. How do we learn from what has worked – and what has not – in designing the future of financing for (digital) development?

The session, organized by the Global Digital Justice Forum, represented by members IT for Change and the Association for Progressive Communications (APC), in partnership with UNDP and Co-Develop, at this historic WSIS+20 moment, seeks to take stock of the learnings and present ideas on innovative financing mechanisms to further digital equality and inclusive digital economies in the ongoing AI transition.

From this standpoint, the session will address the following questions through a panel discussion, also bringing in insights/learnings from initiatives and case studies in the digital and other development sectors:

Q1. What are the primary financing frameworks that have guided the WSIS implementation since 2005, and in what ways have they succeeded or failed?

Q2. How can we centre public accountability and public value in financing digital innovation infrastructures (from connectivity to cloud and AI)?

Q3. What kind of financing architectures are needed for equitable and inclusive innovation futures?

The main ideas will be summarized afterwards in order to fuel discussions and work surrounding the implementation of the results of the WSIS +20 review.

Speakers:

Nonkqubela Thathakahle Jordan-Dyani, Director-General, Department of Communications and Digital Technologies, Republic of South Africa

Yu Ping Chan, Head, Digital Partnerships and Engagement, UNDP

Quintin Chou Lambert, Chief of Office/AI Lead, UN Office for Digital and Emerging Technologies

Matthew McNaughton, Director, Inclusion, Safety & Civil Society Engagement, Co-Develop

Alison Gillwald, Distinguished Fellow, Research ICT Africa

Nandini Chami, Deputy Director and Fellow – Research and Policy Engagement, IT for Change

Moderator:

Anriette Esterhuysen, Senior Advisor, Internet Governance, Policy Advocacy and Strategy, APC

Session Flow

Time	Description
11.45 AM – 11.50 AM	Welcome and introduction by the session moderator, Anriette Esterhuysen
11.50 AM – 12.10 PM	Round 1. What are the primary financing frameworks that have guided the WSIS implementation since 2005, and in what ways have they succeeded or failed? <i>All speakers make a 3-minute input</i>
12.10 PM – 12.30 PM	Round 2. How can we centre public accountability and public value in financing digital innovation infrastructures (from connectivity to cloud and AI)? <i>All speakers make a 3-minute input</i>
12.30 PM – 12.45 PM	Round 3. What kind of financing architectures are needed for equitable and inclusive innovation futures? <i>All speakers make a 2-minute input</i>
12.45 PM – 01.00 PM	A 15-minute open discussion